Yi SHENG

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Behavioral Economics; Experimental Economics; Game Theory
Research Interests: Human-AI interactions; Fairness; Coordination Games; Ethnic Discrimination; Other-regarding Preferences; Costly Signaling.

CURRENT POSITION

New York University Abu Dhabi, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates *2024 - present*
Postdoctoral associate

EDUCATION

Tilburg University, Tilburg, the Netherlands *2018 - 2024*
Ph.D. in Economics, supervised by *Prof. Sigrid Suetens* and *Prof. Jan Potters*
Research Master in Economics, Sep 2019

Shanghai University of Finance and Economics, Shanghai, China *2015 - 2018*
Master-PhD program, M.A. in Economics in 2017

Huazhong University of Science and Technology, Wuhan, China *2011 - 2015*
B.S. in Economics

RESEARCH VISITS

University of California San Diego, San Diego, the United States *October - December 2022*
Visiting graduate student at Rady School of Management

REFERENCES

Prof. Nikos Nikiforakis
Center for Behavioral Institutional Design (C-BID)
Social Science Division
New York University Abu Dhabi
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Prof. Sigrid Suetens
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Tilburg Univerisity
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Prof. Jan Potters
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RESEARCH OUTPUT

Working Papers

Strategic Advice on Coordination by AI and Humans (with Nikos Nikiforakis and Mayada Oudah, *Job market paper*), *pre-registered here*

Large language models (LLMs) are rapidly becoming a new source of advice, guiding human behaviors. Existing evidence largely focuses on non-strategic decisions, yet little is known when choices are strategically interdependent. We focus on an important class of strategic environments, coordination game, which captures a tension between collective efficiency and individual safety. In a preregistered, incentivized experiment, we vary advisor identity, the equilibrium advisors are tasked to promote, and whether both players have access to advice. Recipients follow payoff-dominant advice at similar rates across human and AI advisors. Under a risk-dominant objective, however, receiving AI advice reduces individual choice of the payoff-dominant action by 28.3 percentage points, more than twice the corresponding effect of human advice. Beliefs about partners actions and the advice they would receive differ sharply across treatments, while participants implied choices at a given belief level change little. The AI–human asymmetry persists after controlling for measured linguistic features. Together, these findings suggest that shifts in beliefs, rather than changes in measured social risk threshold, help explain the difference between the effects of AI and human advice on choice in coordination game.

Help to Signal, *submitted to Experimental Economics*, *pre-registered here*

This study investigates whether helping colleagues in a competitive work environment can function as an ability-revealing signal and how employers and competitors respond. I use a real-effort laboratory experiment in which two workers compete for one position and one worker can help the other at a cost. Two treatments, *Signal* and *Baseline*, vary whether employers observe helping decisions before or after hiring. High-type workers help more often when employers observe help before hiring, and employers use this information to improve hiring accuracy. Competitors continue to reward help even when help can reduce their own hiring prospects, suggesting that positive reciprocity remains strong in this setting. The results are consistent with a separating-equilibrium signaling mechanism, while also leaving room for cooperative motives and treatment-induced changes in salience or perceived employer preferences. This study shows that workplace helping can function as an ability signal, allowing employers to infer worker ability from everyday interactions. The results highlight a novel labor-market signaling mechanism and provide a more integrated view of workplace behavior in which cooperation, competition, and reciprocity jointly influence organizational outcomes.

Taste Behind Behavior: A Shock to Ethnic Discrimination (with Zahra Murad, Emel Öztürk, and Sigrid Suetens), *pre-registered here*

Experimental studies are widely used to identify taste-based discrimination. We exploit data from an experiment conducted in two waves in the Netherlands, before and shortly after the 2015 Charlie Hebdo attack by al-Qaeda, to examine how taste is reflected in experimental behavior. Contrary to expectations, trustees became more generous toward participants with a Middle Eastern or North African background after the attack. We argue and provide evidence that this pattern is consistent with an increase in the image-related component of taste. Our findings suggest that experimental measures of taste-based discrimination may conflate concern for others' welfare with concern for being perceived as non-discriminatory.

Other-regarding Ethnic Preferences (with Sigrid Suetens), *pre-registered here*

We study whether other-regarding preferences of the majority population in Germany and the Netherlands depend on the ethnic background of others. To do so, we ran large-scale controlled experiments among the general majority population in both countries. The participants' main task was to make a series of choices on allocating money between themselves and another participant, or between two

other participants. Part of the decision-makers were matched with others who also belonged to the majority population, and another part of the decision-makers were matched with others who belonged to an ethnic minority group. The choices were constructed with the purpose of structurally estimating the parameters of a utility function that allows for a variety of other-regarding preferences, including altruism, inequality aversion, spite, and welfare maximization. We find that, overall, none of the other-regarding preferences depends on the ethnic background of the other.

Work in Progress

Fairness Perceptions in the Presence of AI Assistance (with Siyu Chen), *pre-registered here*

Fairness has been extensively studied in economic and behavioral research, and the growing use of artificial intelligence (AI) introduces new dimensions to this debate. Although AI tools are widely accessible and can enhance productivity, their effectiveness depends on individuals skills and prior experience. We examine how AI assistance (LLMs) influences fairness perceptions in performance-based tasks. We conduct a laboratory experiment in which two participants perform problem-solving tasks under different AI access conditions, while a third-party observer evaluates their performance, is informed about their AI access, and reallocates payoffs accordingly. The experimental design varies whether task performers have no AI access, unilateral AI access, or mutual AI access, and distinguishes between immediate AI assistance and prior AI interaction experience. This design allows us to assess how different forms of AI exposure affect both task performance and third-party fairness judgments.

Human vs AI Advice: Experimental Evidence on Moral Perception and Responsibility (with Yadi Yang)

Publications

Lu, C., J. Li, and Y. Sheng (2020). A study on the negative externality of USD liquidity-based on the asset allocation efficiency of US treasury securities. *The Singapore Economic Review*, 1-29.

PRESENTATIONS

Strategic Advice on Coordination by AI and Humans

4th International Meeting in Experimental Social Science (IMESS) in Paris, France	*August 2026*
BEEF 2026, DUFE, Dalian, China	*May 2026*
LEBPS Seminar, Nankai Uniersity, China	*May 2026*
Seminar@SOE SUFE, Shanghai, China	*May 2026*
C-BID internal seminar, NYUAD	*May 2026*
C-BID IDEAS seminar, NYUAD	*October 2025*

Fairness Perceptions in the Presence of AI Assistance

C-BID IDEAS seminar, NYUAD	*Jan 2026*

Help to Signal

2nd EER Summer School in Behavioural and Experimental Economics, Crete, Greece	*July 2025*
2023 ESA's job-market candidates seminar series, online	*October 2023*
2023 European ESA Meeting in Exeter, UK	*September 2023*
TIBER Symposium 2023 at Tilburg University	*August 2023*
2023 ESA World Meeting in Lyon, France	*June 2023*
Interdisciplinary Brownbag Seminar at Maastricht University	*April 2023*
2022 North-American ESA Meeting in Santa Barbara	*November 2022*
Internal seminar of the Behavioral and Experimental Economics group	*April and September 2022*

Ethnic Salience and Discrimination

International Workshop on Brain and Managerial Decision Making, Hangzhou *June 2025*
2025 Asia-Pacific ESA Meeting, Osaka *March 2025*
8th Maastricht Behavioral Economic Policy Symposium (M-BEPS) *June 2023*
Poster session at Spring School in Behavioral Economics at UC San Diego *October 2022*
Internal seminar of the Behavioral and Experimental Economics group *June 2022*

Other-regarding Ethnic Preferences

2025 Wrold ESA Meeting, Bejing *June 2025*
Workshop in Behavioral and Experimental Economics by Birmingham, Dubai *December 2024*
Interdisciplinary Brownbag Seminar at Maastricht University *May 2024*
ESA 2021 Global Online Conference *July 2021*
2021 CES Annual Conference, online *June 2021*
2021 China Behavioral and Experimental Economics Forum at SUFE *May 2021*
Internal seminar of the Behavioral and Experimental Economics group *January 2021*

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Refereeing

Journal of Behavioral and Experimental Economics, European Economic Review, Journal of Economic Psychology, Frontiers

International Visits

8th Spring School in Behavioral Economics hosted by FAIR (NHH) and Rady School of Management at UCSD *October 24 - 28, 2022*
25th Visiting Graduate Student Workshop in Experimental Economics at Chapman University *January 7 - 12, 2020*

Other Activities

Co-organizer of TIBER symposium 2021 and 2023
Organizer of Tilburg Behavioral & Experimental Economics Reading Group, 2020-2023

TEACHING

Tilburg University, Tilburg, the Netherlands

Macroeconomics for IBA (Lecturers: Louis.B.D.Raes, Malik.Çürük) *Spring 2020 - 2023*
Microeconomics for IBA (Lecturers: Boris van Leeuwen, Mery Ferrando) *Fall 2019 - 2021*

Shanghai University of Finance and Economics, Shanghai, China

Marketing for international undergraduates (Lecturer: Richard F. Foristel) *Fall 2017 - 2018*
Advanced Microeconomics for graduates (Lecturer: Simin He) *Fall 2017 - 2018*
Labor Economics for graduates (Lecturer: Eric Mak) *Fall 2017 - 2018*
Industrial Organization for graduates (Lecturer: Bradley Ruffle) *Summer 2017*
Econometrics for undergraduates (Lecturer: Cong Li) *Spring 2016 - 2017*
Microeconomics Topics for graduates (Lecturers: Quan Wen, Qianfeng Tang, Yongchao Zhang) *Spring 2016 - 2017*

SCHOLARSHIPS AND AWARDS

CentER funding for an international research visit *2022*

CentER Scholarship *2018 - 2019*

Academic Scholarship at SUFE *2015 - 2018*

Best Bachelor Thesis Award in Hubei Province *June 2015*

OTHER INFORMATION

Languages

Native Chinese, fluent English

Technical Skills

z-Tree, oTree, LaTeX, R, Python, Stata, MATLAB, C++